Paul Graham

Co-founder · Y Combinator

79% FIT SCORE

PG has backed multiple developer tools and founder-facing infrastructure through YC and personal angel checks. His recent investments in Bindwell and Channel3 show he still writes seed checks for startups he believes in. VC Whisper's thesis (founders waste time on bad-fit investors) maps to his essays on removing friction and doing things that don't scale. However, PG recently emphasized that founders matter more than ideas, and investor tooling is a narrow TAM compared to his biggest wins. His CNBC comments about non-AI companies being impressive suggest leading with the problem, not the AI.

SWEET SPOT	$150K-$500K
STAGE	Pre-seed / Seed
LINKEDIN	https://uk.linkedin.com/in/paul-graham-899452316
X / TWITTER	https://x.com/paulg
WEB	https://paulgraham.com

PREPARED FOR **VC Whisper**

AI-powered investor research tool for founders. Enter an investor name or paste a pitch transcript, get a full briefing with career history, portfolio, relevant tweets, game plan, and predicted questions.

MARCH 26, 2026

English-American computer scientist, essayist, programmer, and investor. Born November 13, 1964 in Weymouth, Dorset, England. Co-founded Viaweb in 1995 (acquired by Yahoo for $49M, became Yahoo Store). Co-founded Y Combinator in 2005 with Jessica Livingston, Robert Morris, and Trevor Blackwell. YC has funded over 5,000 startups including Airbnb, Stripe, Dropbox, Coinbase, DoorDash, Reddit, and OpenAI. Author of On Lisp, ANSI Common Lisp, and Hackers & Painters. Created the programming language Arc and the news aggregator Hacker News. Still actively angel investing and advising YC startups; sits on YC's board. Lives in England with wife Jessica Livingston since 2016.

Career Path

Co-founder & Board Member, Y Combinator *2005 – present*

Co-founded the most influential startup accelerator with Jessica Livingston, Robert Morris, and Trevor Blackwell. Led YC as president until 2014, now serves on the board (3 of 5 board seats per his March 2026 tweet). YC has funded over 5,000 startups worth over $600B combined, including Airbnb, Stripe, Dropbox, Coinbase, DoorDash, Reddit, and OpenAI.

Co-founder & CEO, Viaweb *1995 – 1998*

Built one of the first SaaS web applications for e-commerce with Robert Morris. Acquired by Yahoo for $49M in 1998. Became Yahoo Store. This experience directly informed his essays on startups and his founding of YC.

Essayist & Author, paulgraham.com *2001 – present*

200+ essays on startups, programming, and technology. paulgraham.com gets ~25M page views/year. 'Founder Mode' (Sep 2024) went viral with 20M+ views on X. Other canonical essays: 'Do Things That Don't Scale', 'Schlep Blindness', 'How to Start a Startup'. Books: On Lisp, ANSI Common Lisp, Hackers & Painters.

Angel Investor, Personal *2014 – present*

62+ personal angel investments post-YC. Recent: Autosana (Feb 2026), Orange Slice (Feb 2026), Channel3 (Dec 2025), Bindwell (Nov 2025), Wordware (Nov 2024). Still names startups for YC batches and does office hours with founders.

PhD Computer Science — Harvard University

AB — Cornell University

Studied Painting — Rhode Island School of Design (RISD) & Accademia di Belle Arti, Florence

Portfolio Companies

COMPANY	STAGE	CATEGORY	DATE	STATUS
Stripe	Seed	Fintech, Payments	2009 (YC S09)	Active ($107B valuation)
Airbnb	Seed	Marketplace, Travel	2009 (YC W09)	IPO (2020, >$100B)
OpenAI	Seed	AI, Research	2015 (YC Research)	Active ($500B valuation)
Dropbox	Seed	SaaS, Cloud Storage	2007 (YC S07)	IPO (2018, $9B)
Coinbase	Seed	Crypto, Finance	2012 (YC S12)	IPO (2021, $86B)
DoorDash	Seed	Marketplace, Delivery	2013 (YC S13)	IPO (2020, $39B)
Reddit	Seed	Social, Community	2005 (YC S05)	IPO (2024, $6.4B)
Scale AI	Seed	AI, Data	2016 (YC S16)	Active ($14B, Meta acquired 49%)
Instacart	Seed	Marketplace, Grocery	2012 (YC S12)	IPO (2023, $10B)
Twitch	Seed	Streaming, Gaming	2007 (YC W07)	Acquired by Amazon ($970M)
Bindwell	Seed (Personal)	AI, Biotech, Agriculture	Nov 2025	Raised $6M seed
Channel3	Seed (Personal)	AI, Commerce, Infrastructure	Dec 2025	Raised $6M seed

Portfolio data from public sources; may be incomplete.

Press & Appearances

Paul Graham on The Social Radars (with Jessica Livingston)

THE SOCIAL RADARS PODCAST · MAR 2026

Appeared alongside Jessica Livingston and Carolynn Levy (3 of 5 YC board members). Discussed YC under Garry Tan's leadership, recalled meeting Mark Zuckerberg circa 2007 and his lack of small talk. Said 'I didn't realize how important small talk was until I met the lack of it.' Fortune, Inc., AOL all covered this episode.

Not Every New Company Needs to Be About AI

CNBC · AUG 2025

Stated the two most impressive companies in the current YC batch were not AI companies. Emphasized 'the founders matter more than the idea. The founders are the best predictor of how a company will do, not the industry it's in.' Told non-AI founders: 'If you're good, good investors will see it.'

Teen Founders Raise $6M to Reinvent Pesticides Using AI, Backed by Paul Graham

TECHCRUNCH · NOV 2025

Met Bindwell's 18- and 19-year-old founders at his home, spoke for 45 minutes, then suggested they pivot from selling tools to discovering molecules themselves. Wrote a personal check. Posted on X: 'The founders will probably do alright. They're smart and have a good idea.'

Founder Mode (essay, 20M+ views on X)

PAULGRAHAM.COM · SEP 2024

Viral essay inspired by Brian Chesky's talk about the failure of 'hire good people and give them room' advice at Airbnb. Coined the terms 'founder mode' vs. 'manager mode'. Argued business schools don't teach founder mode but should. Garnered 20M+ Twitter impressions.

FIT ANALYSIS

THESIS ALIGNMENT	Strong. PG values tools that remove friction from the startup process. His essay 'Schlep Blindness' is about exactly this category of overlooked, painful problem.
PORTFOLIO PATTERN	Moderate. YC has backed founder tools (Clerky, Stripe Atlas) and PG personally backed Channel3 (agentic commerce infrastructure). But VC Whisper's TAM is narrower than PG typically prefers unless the wedge-to-platform story is compelling.
STAGE FIT	Perfect. Pre-seed with traction is PG's sweet spot. His recent personal investments (Bindwell, Channel3, Autosana, Orange Slice) are all seed-stage.
CHECK SIZE FIT	$1.5M raise fits within YC's standard deal plus PG's personal angel range.

Relevant to Your Pitch

> *The founders matter more than the idea. The founders are the best predictor of how a company will do, not the industry it's in.*
>
> CNBC interview · Aug 2025

VC Whisper should lead with the founders and the problem, not 'AI-powered.' PG explicitly said the best companies in the current batch aren't AI. He'll evaluate the founders first.

> *If you want to start a startup to work on a non-AI idea, go ahead. If you're good, good investors will see it, and those are the only ones you want to convince anyway.*
>
> CNBC interview · Aug 2025

Even though VC Whisper does use AI, PG's point is that the problem matters more than the technology. Lead with 'founders waste hours researching investors before every meeting' not 'we use GPT to analyze investors.'

> *Office hours with and investments in startups to help the progress in technology, lots of donations to restrain the bad politicians.*
>
> @paulg on X · Mar 20, 2026

PG is still actively doing office hours and investing in startups as of this week. He's reachable and engaged, not retired.

Recent Posts

> *Those might have been names I considered. They weren't names I recommended. I typically consider about 30-50 names for a startup before I find one that I actually recommend. If I'd reached that stage with your company, there would be only one name on that list.*
>
> @paulg · Mar 25, 2026

> *You don't know what you're talking about. I find new names for several YC startups each batch. Can you give an example of a name I've found for a startup in the past decade that you think is a bad one?*
>
> @paulg · Mar 24, 2026

> *I haven't failed to find a decent .com for a startup yet.*
>
> @paulg · Mar 24, 2026

> *Office hours with and investments in startups to help the progress in technology, lots of donations to restrain the bad politicians.*
>
> @paulg · Mar 20, 2026

> *Some people criticize Garry, but this excerpt from the latest Social Radars episode is a good example of how insiders feel about how he's doing. The 3 of us in this conversation are 3/5 of YC's board.*
>
> @paulg · Mar 20, 2026

Your Game Plan

How They Think

> *Paul Graham evaluates founders in the first 60 seconds. He fires rapid questions to understand what you actually do, not what you think you do. He values conciseness over polish: if you can't explain VC Whisper in one sentence, he'll assume you don't understand your own product. He still names startups for YC batches (considers 30-50 names per company) and does office hours weekly, so he's deeply current on the startup landscape. He gets excited about tools that remove friction from processes everyone accepts as painful. He probes hard on 'why now' and 'why you.' His recent CNBC interview revealed he cares more about founder quality than whether the idea involves AI. He famously hates slides. Just have a conversation.*

Where You Connect

- **You built a tool for founders**

  PG has written repeatedly that founder tools are undervalued ('Schlep Blindness'). VC Whisper removes friction from a process every founder suffers through. His recent Bindwell investment shows he backs tools that fix broken, legacy processes.

- **62K organic launch**

  PG's primary signal at pre-seed is organic demand. 62K people watched the launch tweet. 174 likes. 20 retweets. No paid marketing. This is 'making something people want' in its purest form. He told CNBC: 'good investors will see it.'

- **The stack is the moat**

  VC Whisper combines Exa, Seedlist, xAI, and Browserbase into a single workflow that would take a founder hours to replicate manually. PG backed Channel3 (Dec 2025), which similarly aggregates data into a unified product graph. He values integration-layer businesses.

- **Wedge into the fundraising lifecycle**

  VC Whisper started with pitch analysis (the original 62K launch), then added Prepare (pre-meeting research). The trajectory is clear: investor discovery, CRM, full fundraising stack. PG loves wedge strategies that start narrow and expand. His essay 'Do Things That Don't Scale' is about this exact pattern.

- **He still names YC startups**

  PG's March 2026 tweets show he actively names startups each batch and considers 30-50 names per company. He's hands-on. VC Whisper could be useful to him personally as he evaluates hundreds of startups per batch.

Predicted Questions

- ***"What do you actually do?"***

  One sentence: 'Founders enter an investor's name, and we generate a complete briefing: their career, portfolio, relevant tweets, and a game plan for the meeting.' Then shut up and let him ask follow-ups.

- ***"Why would someone pay for this when they can just Google the investor?"***

  Because Googling takes 2 hours and misses the connections. VC Whisper cross-references their portfolio, recent tweets, and your specific company in 60 seconds. Show him this Paul Graham briefing as the demo. The depth speaks for itself.

- ***"What's the bigger play here?"***

  Fundraising is broken. Founders waste months meeting wrong-fit investors. We started with meeting prep because it's the sharpest pain point. Next: investor discovery (who should you even be talking to), then CRM, then the full fundraising stack. Every founder raises money; the TAM is every startup.

- ***"Why now? What changed?"***

  Three things converged: LLMs that can synthesize research (not just retrieve it), real-time social data APIs (xAI, Exa), and the explosion of angel/seed investors making the matching problem harder. A year ago the API layer didn't exist to build this.

- ***"How do you make money?"***

  Freemium. Free tier with basic briefings. Pro tier ($49/mo) with API-enriched data, PDF exports, unlimited briefings. Enterprise tier for accelerators and law firms who do this for their portfolio companies.

Do Not Mention

- **Don't lead with 'AI-powered'**

  PG told CNBC in Aug 2025 that the two most impressive YC companies weren't AI. He evaluates the problem and the founders, not the tech stack. Lead with 'founders are unprepared for investor meetings' and the result ('a complete briefing in 60 seconds'). Let him discover the AI is sophisticated.

- **Don't compare to LinkedIn Sales Navigator or Crunchbase**

  PG thinks in terms of novel categories, not competitive positioning against incumbents. VC Whisper isn't a better database; it's a new workflow. Comparing to existing tools makes it feel incremental.

- **Don't oversell the naming angle**

  PG takes startup naming seriously (considers 30-50 names per company, tweets defensively about it). Don't casually mention naming or branding unless you've thought deeply about it. He'll notice if your company name isn't great.

Other Investors to Pursue

Jared Friedman · Y Combinator **85%**

Current YC Managing Partner and board member alongside PG. Deeply technical. Has been vocal about developer tools and founder infrastructure. Would understand the API orchestration architecture immediately.

Lead with: Show him the tech stack: Exa + Seedlist + xAI + Browserbase orchestrated into a single query. He'll appreciate the engineering depth.

x

Garry Tan · Y Combinator **82%**

Current YC President & CEO. PG is publicly supportive of his leadership (March 2026 tweet). If PG is interested, Garry is the operational decision-maker who would champion a YC batch acceptance.

Lead with: PG and Garry are aligned. If PG endorses, mention his enthusiasm. Garry co-founded Posterous and Initialized Capital, so he knows founder tools.

x

Elad Gil · Angel / Color Genomics **78%**

Prolific angel investor in developer and founder tools. Wrote 'High Growth Handbook.' Understands the fundraising process deeply from both sides.

Lead with: His own book advocates thorough investor research before meetings. VC Whisper automates the exact process he recommends.

x

Sarah Tavel · Benchmark **72%**

Framework-driven investor (Hierarchy of Engagement). Would evaluate VC Whisper through engagement depth: do founders come back before every meeting?

Lead with: Repeat usage data. If founders use it before every meeting, that's the 'core action' she looks for. Fundraising prep is inherently recurring.

QUICK REFERENCE

THESIS	Founders matter more than ideas. Tools that remove friction from painful processes are undervalued.
STYLE	60-second evaluation. Rapid questions. Hates slides. Wants conversations. Still does weekly office hours.
KEY QUESTIONS	1. What do you actually do? 2. Why pay vs. Googling? 3. What's the bigger play?
PROOF POINTS	• 62K launch views, zero paid marketing • Cross-references 5 data sources in 60 seconds • Wedge into full fundraising stack
AVOID	Don't lead with 'AI-powered.' Don't compare to Crunchbase. Don't be casual about naming.